

6.4 Firewalling The Demons

We have seen how easy it is to connect to the Internet using a modem or a network card. However, life is not all rosy, and your Internet experience can turn sour if you do not take the proper precautions. One of the most important tools in safeguarding your computer on the Internet is a firewall. Over the next few pages, we will understand software firewalls in brief and also learn how to configure and use them to our advantage.

We will only talk about free firewalls for home users. This is because paid firewalls may not find many takers in the home-user segment, since free software such as ZoneAlarm Pro can do the same job. Windows XP SP2, in fact, comes with its own, built-in firewall. The configuration of the firewalls does take some time but once complete, your PC stands protected and safe from attacks over the Internet.

First let's talk about one of the best free (for home use) firewall around. We're talking about ZoneAlarm. The basic version of ZoneAlarm is free, but if you want to upgrade, you will have to pay for it.

Installation

For installing ZoneAlarm, you can download it off the Internet or you install it from the *Digit May 2005* DVD. For installation, double click on the setup.exe file and the installation starts automatically. (The file will be called something like zlsSetup_55_094_000.exe)

1. The first screen will ask you if you want to install the free version of ZoneAlarm or if you want to install a free 15-day trial of ZoneAlarm Pro. You can choose to install ZoneAlarm PRO for 15 days and at the end of the trial, pay for upgrading to the full version or go back to using the free version of ZoneAlarm.